The common liberal assumption that the BJP is winning elections because it has more money simply does not hold up. In other words, the BJP, even now, is still far away from the backlash that the BSP faced because it started fielding a disproportionately high percentage of rich candidates in UP.

Conclusion

This chapter has shown how caste remains the central lever of power in Indian politics, how the BJP rearranged its caste matrix, giving much greater representation to OBCs, and the upward impact this had on its political fortunes. This is not to argue that caste groups are monoliths, or that everyone in a particular caste group votes the same way. Far from it. However, the BJP's strategies underscored how powerful caste identities remain the truest indices of social power in India. In a different context, the American journalist Isabel Wilkerson, in her book *Caste: The Origins of Our Discontent*, has used the C-word to show how the deeply embedded racial attitudes in the United States mirror the inbuilt social inequities of the caste ladder in India.[60] While India and the US are very different societies, and caste dynamics keep changing, the point is that political representation matters immensely. The BJP's leaders understood this, and the changes they made to their organisation in terms of caste representation at every organisational level played a vital role in its electoral triumphs.

This chapter has provided new evidence to show how our understanding of the BJP's caste representation has so far not kept pace with ground realities. The revelations of the Mehta–Singh Index should lead to much-needed soul-searching as well as a correction of methodologies and dominant narratives among academic experts who study caste patterns in political representation. These findings put a very serious question mark not only on their academic research—which ignored observations from a whole host of journalists on the ground in UP, all pointing strongly to a contrary trend[61]—but also on the poor oversight mechanism of the university research centres that churned out the wrong data and the peer-reviewed academic journals that published them. There is need for